

Think and Speak Like a British Person

In this lesson, we're taking the indirect nature of British speech head-on. We are about to explore the unique way Brits use English, so you understand the real meaning behind common British phrases and expressions. You will learn to read between the lines of British politeness and understatement. By the end of this lesson, you'll not only grasp what Brits say but also what they truly mean. I've also included an activity at the end to see just how British you are!

What do Brits really mean?

In this lesson, we're going to read some text messages from a British person (**Bea**) and someone who speaks English as a second language (**Ana**) to their mutual friend, Jill. First, we'll see what Ana understood, and then we'll have a look at what Bea actually meant.

Text Message: 1



Now, if someone tells you that **you've caught the sun**, it's not usually a compliment. It means you look **sunburnt**.

We say both **sunburned** - /'sʌnbɜːnd/ and **sunburnt** - /'sʌnbɜːnt/ in British English.

1. **you've caught the sun** *idiom* /juːv kɔːt ðə sʌn/ - to look sunburnt/sunburned
 - You've certainly caught the sun today; your cheeks are quite rosy.
2. **to look like a lobster** *idiom* /lʊk laɪk ə 'lɒbstə/ - to look/seem very red
 - After spending the day at the beach without sunscreen, Jodie looked like a lobster.

Text Message: 2

Ana:

Bea looked a bit unwell, but she must be alright because she just said, "Oh... I've felt better." And then she said, "Can't complain."

Bea:

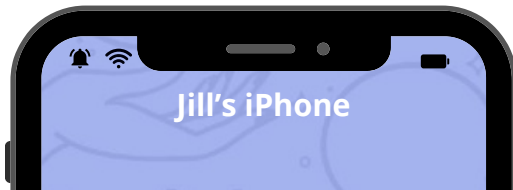
I felt like death warmed up when I saw her. I wanted to complain so much.



Ah yes, the classic British stiff upper lip. We rarely say how we really feel, so if someone says, **I've felt better** it means **they feel terrible**.

We can also say **been better** to describe **how we feel** or **how our life is going in general**. Either way, things are going terribly. And **can't complain** usually means that **you'd like to complain, but you won't**.

3. **I've felt better** phrase /aɪv felt 'betə/ - I feel terrible
 - Today's been a bit rough. Let's just say I've felt better.
4. **been better** phrase /bi:n 'betə/ - to feel down or experience difficulties
 - A: How's it going, mate?
 - B: Been better. This week has been absolutely terrible!
5. **can't complain** phrase /kɑ:nt kəm'pleɪn/ - to express that things are good enough, even if not perfect
 - A: How's your new job?
 - B: Well, there's a bit of a learning curve, but I can't complain.
6. **to feel like death warmed up** phrase /fi:l laɪk deθ wɔ:md ʌp/ - to feel extremely unwell
 - A: You don't look well at all. Are you okay?
 - B: No, I feel like death warmed up. I think I've caught the flu.

Text Message: 3

Ana:

She said the renovations were “Not bad. Getting there.” So they must be almost finished. She did mention that knocking down the wall in the kitchen hadn’t quite gone as planned. But she said, “no harm done.” So I guess it’s all gone well.



Bea:

As you know, the renovations are in chaos. We’ve barely started. And knocking that wall down almost brought the entire ceiling down. There was a lot of damage.

Not bad in ‘British’ either means **bad** or **excellent**.

How are you?

Not bad, thanks.



This person might be having the worst day ever or they might have just won the lottery and got engaged - *you'll never know*.

In this case, you saw **Not bad. Getting there**. We usually use this to talk about a project, and it means **everything is terrible and we're nowhere near finished**.

The other phrases in those messages were **it didn't quite go as planned**, meaning **something went terribly wrong**, and **no harm done**, usually meaning **a lot of damage was done**.

Another similar phrase like this is **a bit of an upset**, which means, again, **something has gone very wrong**.

7. **not bad** phrase /nɒt bæd/ - implies things are less than ideal

- A: How's the redesign of your website coming along?
- B: Not bad, but there's still a lot to do.

8. **it didn't quite go as planned** phrase /ɪt 'dɪdnt kwaɪt ɡəʊ æz plænd/ - something went wrong or didn't happen as expected

- A: Tell me about your presentation!
- B: To tell you the truth, it didn't quite go as planned - my laptop died halfway through.

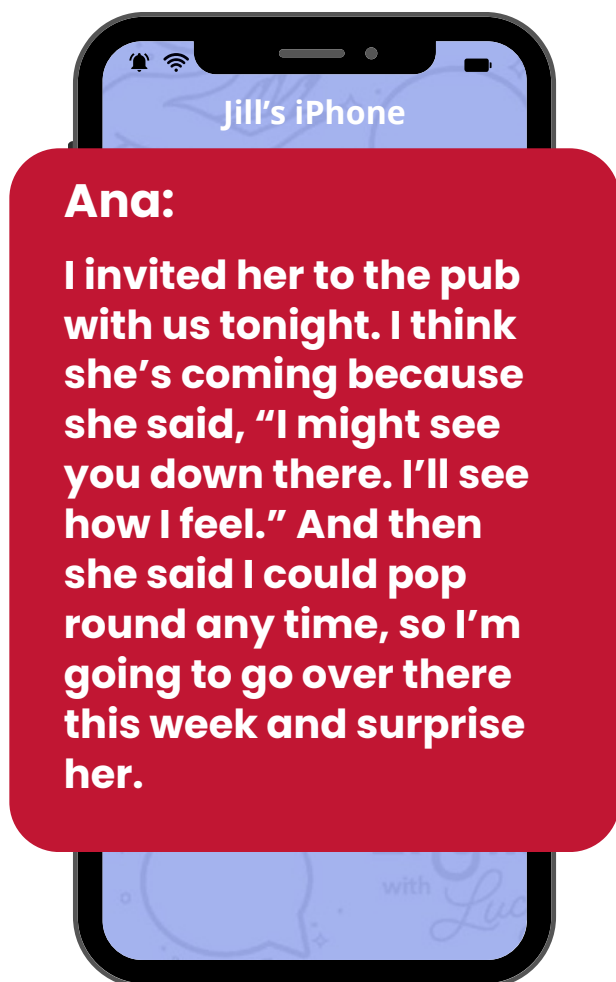
9. **no harm done** phrase /nəʊ hɑ:m dʌn/ - used to say that something bad happened, even though the words suggest everything is fine

- A: I'm doing to need an extension on this project. I'm sorry!
- B: Sure, no harm done. But this is completely unprofessional and cannot happen again.

10. **a bit of an upset** phrase /ə bɪt əv ən 'ʌpset/ - something went really wrong

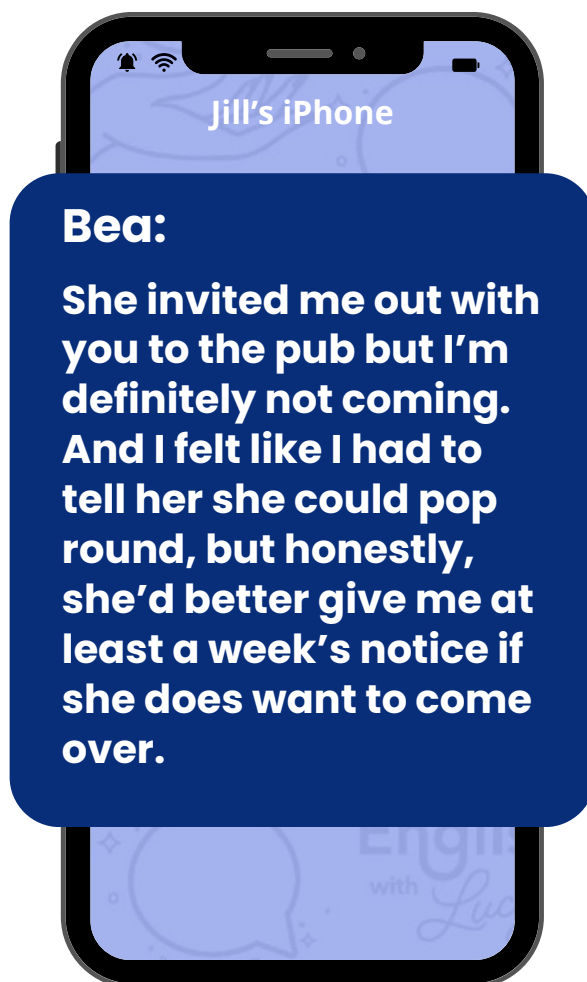
- The football match was a bit of an upset. I really thought this was going to be our year!

Text Message: 4



Ana:

I invited her to the pub with us tonight. I think she's coming because she said, "I might see you down there. I'll see how I feel." And then she said I could pop round any time, so I'm going to go over there this week and surprise her.



Bea:

She invited me out with you to the pub but I'm definitely not coming. And I felt like I had to tell her she could pop round, but honestly, she'd better give me at least a week's notice if she does want to come over.

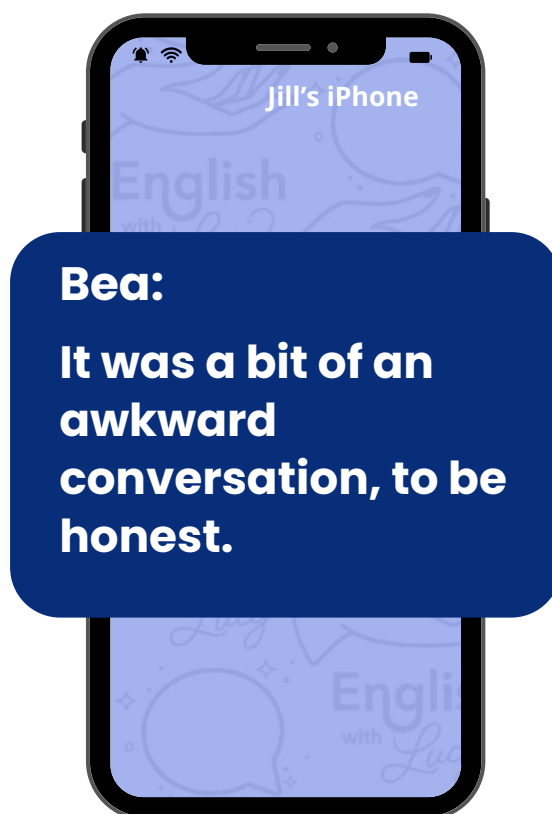
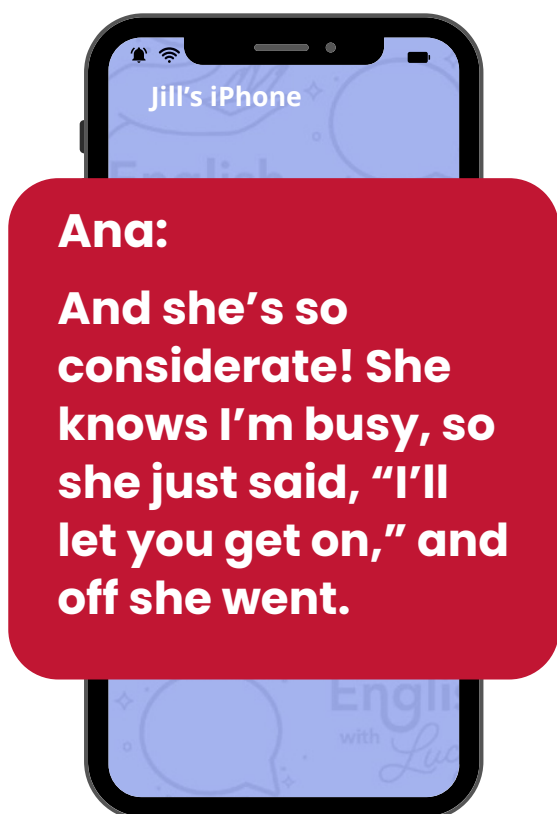
If you invite a British person somewhere and they say **I might see you down there** or **I'll see how I feel** they mean **they are not coming** wherever you've invited them, but they're too polite to just say, "*I don't want to come. I want to drink wine on the sofa with my dog.*"

We also often tell someone **to pop round** any time or **drop by sometime**. We don't usually mean it, and **you shouldn't turn up unannounced**.

11. **I might see you down there** phrase /aɪ maɪt siː ju daʊn ðeə/- in general, the person doesn't plan to go where they've been invited
- A: Are you coming to Mike's party tonight?
 - B: Yeah... I might see you down there.

12. **I'll see how I feel** *phrase* /aɪl siː haʊ aɪ fiːl/ - a polite way of saying the person is unlikely to attend
- A: Will you join us for dinner tomorrow?
 - B: I'm just getting over a cold - I'll see how I feel.
13. **pop round any time** *phrase* /pɒp raʊnd 'enɪ taɪm/ - despite sounding like an open invitation, it's usually not meant literally, and you shouldn't visit without arranging it first
- Feel free to pop round any time, but give me a ring before you do so!
14. **drop by sometime** *phrase* /ˌdrɒp 'baɪ sʌmtaɪm/ - similar to 'pop round any time', this is often used casually and doesn't usually mean the person expects you to visit without notice.
- I know you don't come into the city very often, but feel free to drop by sometime.

Text Message: 5



A classic end!

I'll let you get on or **I'll let you get back to it** mean, **I want this conversation to end, but I still want to be polite.**

15. **I'll let you get on/back to it** phrase /aɪl let ju get ɒn/bæk tu ɪt/ - a polite way to end a conversation

- Well, I'll let you get back to it! I don't want to take up too much of your time.

That's the end of our conversation, but I want to give you a few more examples that I love.

16. **I'd love to but...** phrase /aɪd lʌv tu: bʌt/ - the person does not actually want to do what is being suggested

- A: Are you coming to the concert?
- B: I'd love to, but I'm having dinner with my parents.

17. **let's put a date in the diary** phrase /lets put ə deɪt ɪn ðə 'daɪəri/ - the person doesn't really intend to make a specific plan

- A: We should catch up soon.
- B: Yes, let's put a date in the diary.

18. **we must meet up properly some time** phrase /wi: mʌst mi:t ʌp 'prɒpəli sʌm taɪm/ - often used to politely avoid making a definite plan

- It's been ages since we've seen each other. We must meet up properly some time.

19. **oh, I really mustn't** phrase /əʊ aɪ 'ri:əli 'mʌsnt/ - paradoxically, this can mean the person actually would like what's being offered

- A: Would you like some cake?
- B: Oh, I really mustn't. Alright, go on, just a small piece.

20. **only if you're having one** phrase /'əʊnli ɪf jɔː 'hævɪŋ wʌn/ - the person wants whatever is being offered but doesn't want to cause an inconvenience
- A: Do you want a coffee?
 - B: Only if you're having one.
21. **Excuse me, is anyone sitting here?** phrase /ɪk'skjuːz miː ɪz 'eniwʌn 'sɪtɪŋ hɪə/ - a polite but firm way of asking someone to move their belongings so they can sit down.
- Excuse me, is anyone sitting here? The bus is quite full today.

Extra Phrases You Might Hear In The Office

1. **whatever you think is best** phrase /'wɒtevə juː θɪŋk ɪz best/ - often means the speaker disagrees but will not argue
- We should probably cancel the meeting, but whatever you think is best.
2. **sorry to bother you again...** phrase /'sɒri tuː 'bɒðə juː ə'geɪn/ - used to point out repeated requests or ignored messages
- Sorry to bother you again, but I still haven't received your feedback.
3. **interesting choice** phrase /'ɪntrɪstɪŋ tʃɔɪs/ - the speaker doubts or disagrees with the decision
- The fonts you chose for the web page were an interesting choice, to say the least.
4. **help me understand...** phrase /help miː ʌn'dʒːstænd/ - a lead-in to question or challenge a decision
- Help me understand why we're not targeting a larger market.
5. **It's fine. I'll just do it myself** phrase /ɪts faɪn aɪl dʒʌst duː ɪt maɪ'self/ - shows dissatisfaction with someone else's effort or lack thereof
- I know you haven't finished this task yet, but it's fine. I'll just do it myself.

QUIZ!

Complete the conversation using the phrases in the box.

Dave and Mike are co-workers. They haven't had a proper chat in a few weeks, so they have decided to meet up at their favourite pub to catch up. Mike headed to the pub first to get a table.

Dave: Excuse me, (1) _____?

Mike: Of course not, mate; all yours! Right, so tell me all about this new project at work.

Dave: Yeah... well, it's been a bit of a challenge. It (2) _____ – had a major glitch yesterday.

Mike: Ah, (3) _____, I hope. Oh, and before I forget, are you coming to Sarah's get-together next weekend?

Dave: I (4) _____. You know how it is.

Mike: Sure, sure. And how's everything else? You look a bit off.

Dave: (5) _____. I just have a lot on my plate at the moment, but things are looking up.

Mike: Happy to hear it. Hey, do you fancy a pint?

Dave: Only (6) _____. Don't want to drink alone.

Mike: Of course, I'm having one! But just one, I've got to get going soon.

Dave: Right, well don't be a stranger. It's always great chatting with you.

Mike: Agreed. And feel free (7) _____ if you need a break from the chaos.

Dave: Thanks, mate. Same goes for you. If you're ever in my neck of the woods, (8) _____.

Mike: Will do.

Phrase Bank

a. didn't quite go as planned	b. might see you down there	c. if you're having one	d. no harm done
e. to pop round any time	f. drop by sometime	g. is anyone sitting here	h. Been better

The End!

f(8) e(7) c(6) h(5) d(4) b(3) a(2) g(1)

